



I**T WAS A HOT,** sultry day in April 1986 when Javed Miandad smashed Chetan Sharma for a last-ball six to steer Pakistan to victory in the Austral-Asia Cup final. All around me, the stadium broke into tears of joy and heartbreak. That was my introduction to Sharjah, an Emirate best known for hosting India-Pakistan cricket matches. But that was a long time ago and I was just a child. In the ensuing years, Sharjah, the UAE's third largest Emirate, has established itself as the region's cultural heart.

Bordering Dubai on its southern side, the more traditional Sharjah (alcohol is not served and visitors

should be mindful of the local culture when dressing up) is distinguishing itself from its glitzy neighbour by preserving its Emirati heritage through its distinctive architecture and culture. The Sharjah Biennial, a regional festival of contemporary art, was established in 1993 by Sheikh Dr. Sultan Bin Mohammad Al Qasimi, the ruler of Sharjah and a passionate supporter of the arts. Subsequently, UNESCO designated Sharjah as the Cultural Capital of the Arab World in 1998.

This Sharjah—with its innumerable museums (over 15 at last count), art and light festivals, beautiful waterfronts, luxury hotels and the